

society & the arts CINEMA

■ By Jhilmil Motihar

Most people would agree that Bipasha Basu is a fairly light weight woman. Picking her up shouldn't be a painful task for any man worth his muscle. But at a recent stage show in Nagpur, Salman Khan refused to twirl the actress in the air during the final rehearsals. It had nothing to do with his strength or Basu's weight, of course. Says a director who has worked with John Abraham, "that was obviously an extension of Salman's now famous rivalry with John". The two warring actors didn't always have their swords drawn. They, in fact, were even working on two films—*Babul* and *Salaam-e-Ishq*. Allegedly, trouble started during their 2006 Rockstars tour when Salman wanted all the actors to pay the junior dancers, but Abraham refused to do so.

Tabloids thrive on this and film glossies make a living out of reporting about star differences or in not-so-polite terms, spats. The result: actors or stars, depending on how you see them, often refuse to work with each other. The refusal is most often subtle, but like the recent Salman and Abraham fracas or the not so recent Salman-Vivek Oberoi spat, rather public. Excellent fodder for stories, these spats often lead to a larger problem for the industry—that of casting. Their only solution—to either let go of the film or replace one of the warring stars. Pritish Nandy, founder of Pritish Nandy Communications, says that stars having problems with each other is common and happens all the time. "We had to stall the movie *Sahib, Biwi Aur Ghulam*, when Salman and John Abraham developed a personal problem."

Every year Bollywood releases about 100 mainstream films. According to a film director, the number of "saleable stars" is about seven. Though, a producer or filmmaker may want a big star who ensures a good opening, it isn't possible for all films to have a star. The options become further limited when personal and professional differences come in the way and actors and actresses start opting out of or turning down films because they don't like their co-stars. Producer Mahesh Bhatt says, "Actors choosing to work with certain people is an automatic byproduct of

success." As director Kunal Kohli points out, when two people are stars in their own right, they obviously want to know who they are working with. "There's no denying that this exists in the industry but you have to work around it," he says. Kohli, who achieved a coup of sorts when he cast Aamir Khan and Kajol in *Fanaa*, agrees that getting the two together again might be an almost impossible task because they're both very fussy. "For them to like everything—the script, the director and the producer—once again will be very difficult," he says.

But the hit pair of Aamir and Kajol

STAR SPATS

They were once the talk of the town. Sizzling on-screen, a virtual gold mine for producers. But today they don't see eye to eye. At the losing end are filmmakers left with fewer and fewer options.

isn't a one-off example. A number of pairs that became the audience's darlings in the past may now never be seen on-screen together because of their personal liaisons that transformed into great chemistry but also led to awkward situations. Aishwarya Rai Bachchan's 'differences' with Salman are widely publicised and as a director who's famous for his multi-starrers, says, "I don't think people even try to get them together anymore." Aishwarya's casting problems don't end with Salman. The director adds, "It is a well-known fact that actors like Shah Rukh Khan and Aamir Khan will also not work with Aishwarya for various professional and personal reasons." So what does this leave her with? Considering her A-list status, it wouldn't be wrong to suggest that Abhishek Bachchan could be one of her only heroes. "This will certainly affect Rai's career to a certain extent," he says.

Another woman who has been in turbulent waters for quite a while is Kareena Kapoor. There has been speculation of her problems with Hrithik Roshan after their alleged romance. While the two worked in four consecu-

Akshay Kumar-Priyanka Chopra

Total Box Office impact:

... Rs 56 cr

Films: *Waqt* (2005), *Aitraaz* (2004), *Mujhse Shaadi Karogi* (2004), *Andaaz* (2003)

LOVE LOST: Reports of a great on-screen chemistry led to their becoming wary of working with each other. Allegedly, Priyadarshan wanted to cast them for his film *Bhul Bhulaiya* but had to take on Vidya Balan instead.

Aamir Khan-Kajol

Total Box Office impact:

... Rs 95 cr

Films: *Ishq* (1997), *Fanaa* (2006)

LOVE LOST: The two are as fussy as can be. It would be almost impossible to pair them again as obtaining the right combination of the script, the director and the producer, would be very difficult.

